

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

A Novelization

The wind didn't howl; it accused. It pressed against the frosted glass of the farmhouse windows, seeking a way in, like a memory you couldn't drink away. Inside, the air was thick with the scent of pine cleaner and the metallic tang of old blood, scrubbed but never truly gone.

Erin Bruner sat in the back of the town car, watching the grey landscape of the Midwest blur into a smear of slate and snow. She checked her BlackBerry for the third time in a minute. No signal. Just the "Searching..." icon spinning its little wheel of futility.

"Great," she muttered, her voice tight, the word barely a vapor cloud in the chilled air of the car. "Just great."

She was a creature of the city, of courtrooms with fluorescent lights and judges who operated on schedules, not seasons. This... this was a different world. Cornfields that went on forever, hiding God knows what in their rusted rows. The farmhouse where Emily Rose had died—or been murdered, depending on which jury you asked—sat on a rise, looking like a skull bleaching in the winter sun. It was the kind of place where silence wasn't empty; it was heavy.

Father Richard Moore was waiting for her in the county jail, but she needed to see the place first. The scene of the crime. Or the miracle.

"We're here, Ms. Bruner," the driver said. He didn't look back. He just stared at the house through the windshield, his hands tight on the wheel, knuckles white. He didn't want to be here either. Maybe he'd heard the stories. Maybe he just smelled the wrongness of it.

Erin stepped out. The cold hit her like a physical blow, stripping the warmth from her expensive wool coat in seconds. She walked up the porch steps, the wood groaning under her heels. It sounded like bones snapping.

Focus, Erin. It's just a house. Just wood and nails and a tragedy that's going to make you Senior Partner.

She pushed the door open.

The silence inside was heavier than the cold. It was a listening silence.

Flashback. Six months ago.

The room smelled of sickness and ozone, an impossible combination, like a hospital struck by lightning.

Emily Rose lay on her bed, her body arched in a way that defied anatomy. Her spine was a bow drawn to the breaking point, the vertebrae popping wetly, like green wood in a fire. The sound was nauseating—a wet, grinding *click-clack* that echoed off the peeling wallpaper.

Shadows didn't just fall in the room; they *crawled*. They oozed from the corners, sticky and semi-solid, reaching for the girl on the bed. They were heavy, viscous, smelling of sulfur and wet dog.

"Gamaliel!" she shrieked, but the voice wasn't hers. It was deeper, a grinding of stones in a dry riverbed. It came from her chest, bypassing the vocal cords entirely. "I am the leech in the wound! I am the rot in the root!"

Her fingers clawed at the mattress, nails tearing through the sheet, through the ticking, into the horsehair stuffing below, shredding her own fingertips until the blood slicked the fabric. She didn't feel it. The vessel was merely meat to be used, to be worn until it broke.

Father Moore stood at the foot of the bed, his stole purple against the darkness, his bible a shield of paper and ink against a hurricane of hate. His hands shook, not from fear, but from the sheer physical pressure of the air in the room. It felt like standing at the bottom of the ocean.

"I command you!" Moore roared, sweat stinging his eyes, his voice cracking under the strain. "By the power of Christ, tell me your name!"

The girl's head snapped toward him—too fast, with a *crack* of cartilage that made Moore flinch. Her eyes were rolled back, showing only the whites, veined with burst capillaries like a roadmap of hell.

"Names?" The voice giggled, a wet, bubbling sound that sprayed spittle mixed with blood. "We are Legion. We are the biting frost. We are the cancer in the bone. We are the ones who dwell in the spaces between your prayers."

The window exploded. Not outward, but inward. Shards of glass flew like shrapnel, embedding themselves in the walls, in the floor, scoring Moore's cheek. The wind rushed in, screaming, carrying the smell of the frozen fields and something older, something from beneath the earth.

Present Day. The Courtroom.

"All rise."

The bailiff's voice was bored. Another day, another dollar. He didn't look up from his roster.

Erin stood, smoothing her skirt. She took a breath, holding it, letting the sterile air center her. She looked at the jury. Twelve people. Farmers, teachers, a mechanic. A woman with a knitting bag. A man with dirt under his nails. Good, honest folk who went to church on Sunday and feared God. That was the problem. They feared the Devil too. And they were looking at Father Moore like he had brought the Devil to town.

Ethan Thomas stood at the prosecution table. He looked like a choir director who'd just caught a boy smoking behind the vestry. Smug. Righteous. He wore a suit that was ten years out of date but perfectly pressed. He caught Erin's eye and gave a small, polite nod. The kind of nod you give the executioner before the hood goes on.

"Mr. Thomas, your opening statement," Judge Brewster said. She adjusted her glasses, looking over the rims. She wanted this over. She wanted a plea deal. She wasn't going to get one.

Thomas walked to the jury box. He didn't use notes. He just leaned on the railing, looking them in the eye, one by one, establishing a connection. A bond of reasonable men against the irrational.

"This is a simple case," Thomas began, his voice warm, like melted butter on toast. "It's a tragedy, yes. A young girl, sick, confused, needing medical help. And she was denied that help. Not by a monster. But by a man who thought he knew better than doctors. A man who let superstition overrule science."

He paused, letting the silence hang. He walked down the line, nodding to the grandmother in the front row.

"We call it negligent homicide," he said softly. "Emily Rose called it... torture."

Erin watched him work. He was good. He was weaving a narrative of common sense, of logic. He was painting Moore not as a villain, but as a fool. And fools went to prison. The jury was nodding. They liked simple. Simple was safe.

She looked at Father Moore. He sat still, his hands folded on the table. He wasn't looking at the jury. He was looking at the empty air above the judge's head, as if he could see something they couldn't. His lips moved silently. Prayer? Or pleading?

What do you see, Father? Erin thought. *Do you see the angels? Or do you just see the bars closing in?*

She stood up. Her turn.

"Ladies and gentlemen," Erin said, her voice cutting through the warmth Thomas had built. She didn't smile. She didn't lean on the railing. She stood straight, a pillar of modern law. "My colleague tells you this is a simple case. He tells you it's about science versus superstition."

She walked to the center of the room. High heels clicking on the linoleum. *Click. Click. Click.* Like a clock counting down. She stopped in front of the mechanic.

"But we aren't here to judge science. And we aren't here to judge faith. We are here to judge *facts*. And the fact is... Emily Rose was not just sick. She was... occupied."

She let the word hang there. *Occupied.* It sounded military. Invasive.

"And when medicine failed," Erin said, locking eyes with the foreman, "Father Moore was the only one who answered the call. When the pills didn't stop the voices, when the doctors turned away... he stepped into the darkness."

The Cell. Night.

The fluorescent buzz was louder here. It drilled into Erin's skull, a constant reminder of the cage they were in.

"You need to take the plea, Father," Erin said. She was tired. The coffee had worn off hours ago, leaving only the jittery crash and the headache behind her eyes. "Reckless endangerment. Time served. You walk out of here. The Archdiocese is pushing for it. They want this to go away."

Moore looked up. In the harsh light, he looked ancient. Deep lines etched his face, maps of sleepless nights.

"I cannot," he said softy.

"Why?" Erin slammed her hand on the metal table. The sound rang out, sharp and angry. "Because of pride? You want to be a martyr? Because let me tell you, martyrs don't get book deals, Richard. They get dead."

"No," Moore said. He leaned forward. His eyes were clear, terrifyingly clear. "Because the story must be told. That is what she wanted. That is why she stayed."

"Stayed?" Erin blinked. "She died, Richard. She didn't stay. She died screaming in pain because you told her to stop taking the Gambutrol."

"She had a choice," Moore whispered. "They gave her a choice. To leave... or to suffer, so that the world would know the Devil is real. She chose to stay."

Erin stared at him. The air in the cell seemed to drop ten degrees. The smell of pine cleaner vanished, replaced by something faint, sweet, and rotten. The smell of the farmhouse.

"And if the world knows the Devil is real," Moore said, a ghost of a smile on his lips, "then they must also know that God is real."

Erin shivered. For a second, just a second, she wasn't the shark in the suit. She was a little girl in the dark, wondering what was under the bed.

"Fine," she whispered, gathering her files. "We do it your way. But if we lose... you don't just go to jail. You go to hell."

Moore nodded, and his eyes drifted back to the empty corner of the cell. "I am already there, Erin. I have been there since the night she died."

Chapter 2: The Scent of Burning Leaves

The courtroom smelled of floor wax and judgment. It was a sterile, controlled environment, the natural predator of the chaotic unknown. Erin Bruner stood at the defense table, her fingers tracing the edge of a manila folder. Inside were medical records. Scientific facts. The armor of the modern world.

But across the aisle, Ethan Thomas was dismantling that armor, one witness at a time.

"Dr. Mueller," Thomas said, pacing in front of the jury box like a metronome. "In your expert opinion, what was Emily Rose suffering from?"

Dr. Mueller, a man whose face seemed composed entirely of right angles, adjusted his glasses. "Epilepsy. Specifically, psychomotor epilepsy. It causes seizures, hallucinations, muscle rigidity. It is a serious condition, but it is treatable."

"Treatable," Thomas repeated, nodding to the jury. "If the patient takes their medication."

Erin looked at Father Moore. He was staring at his hands again. He knew what was coming. The narrative of the negligent priest. The primitive man who threw away the pills and picked up a crucifix.

Flashback. The University Campus. Autumn.

The world was burning. Not with fire, but with color. The trees on the campus quad were a riot of gold and crimson, shedding their leaves in a slow, drifting rain.

Emily Rose walked through them, hugging her books to her chest. She was nineteen. She was happy. She was thinking about Jason, the boy with the shy smile in her philosophy class, and about the scholarship that had brought her here, far from the farm and the silence of the fields.

She felt like she was finally the protagonist of her own life. Not 'Nathaniel's daughter' or 'the girl from the sticks.' She was Emily. Just Emily.

But then the smell hit her.

It wasn't the smell of autumn leaves. It was the smell of something burning. Not wood. Hair. Or meat.

She stopped. The laughter of students playing frisbee nearby seemed to stretch, warping into slow motion. The sound deepened, becoming a guttural roar.

The shadows of the trees lengthened. They didn't just stretch; they reached. The sunlight turned a sickly, bruised purple, casting a pall over the quad that no one else seemed to notice.

"Emily?"

She turned. No one was there. Just the empty path. But the air was cold. Freezing. In the middle of October, she could see her breath puffing out in white clouds.

"Who's there?" she whispered.

You know who.

The thought wasn't hers. It slid into her mind like a needle, cold and sharp.

She started to run. She ran back to her dorm room, slamming the door, locking it. As if a lock could keep out what was already inside.

That night, the first seizure hit.

It wasn't like the epilepsy the doctor described. It was a possession. Her body locked up, muscles seizing with such force she thought her bones would snap. She fell to the floor, her vision tunneling into darkness.

And in the darkness, there were faces. Twisted, mocking faces that looked like gargoyles carved from rotting meat.

"Emily..." they whispered. "We're hungry."

Present Day. The Courtroom.

"She saw faces," Erin said on cross-examination. "She heard voices. Dr. Mueller, isn't it true that the medication you prescribed, Gambutrol, has a failure rate of nearly thirty percent for this specific type of epilepsy?"

Dr. Mueller stiffened. "No drug is perfect, Ms. Bruner. But to stop taking it entirely..."

"She didn't just stop," Erin interrupted, her voice sharp. "She stopped because it wasn't working. Because the visions were getting worse. Because she felt... trapped."

She turned to the jury. "Imagine being locked in a room with your worst nightmares, and the only key you're given... doesn't fit the lock."

She sat down. She felt the eyes of the jury on her. Some were nodding. Doubt. That was all she needed. Reasonable doubt.

But then she looked at Father Moore. He wasn't looking at her with gratitude. He was looking at her with pity.

"You are fighting the wrong battle, Erin," he whispered when she leaned in.

"I'm keeping you out of prison," she hissed back.

"Prison is just a place," Moore said. "What is coming for you... is not."

Chapter 3: The Prescription of Ash

The winter deepened. The trial dragged on, a slow excavation of tragedy. But the real story wasn't in the courtroom. It was in the tapes.

Erin sat in her apartment. It was a high-rise, glass and steel, a fortress of modernity. She had a glass of scotch in one hand and the remote in the other.

"Exhibit 4A," she muttered. "The first recording."

She pressed play.

The sound that filled her living room wasn't human.

It was a wet, tearing sound. Like a sheet being ripped, but the sheet was made of vocal cords. A sound that bypasses the ear and vibrates the marrow.

"One... two... three... four... five... six..."

Emily's voice. Counting. But under it, another voice. A low, grinding bass that vibrated the speakers.

"We are the ones who wait..."

Erin's cat, a sleek Siamese named Bastian, hissed and bolted from the room. The lights in the apartment flickered.

Erin stared at the tape player. The air in the room grew heavy. Static charged the hairs on her arms.

It's just a tape, she told herself. *Just magnetic tape and a sick girl.*

But then the smell came. The same smell from the farmhouse. Pine cleaner and rot.

She stood up, her heart hammering against her ribs. "Is someone there?"

Silence.

Then, the door to her bedroom slammed shut.

She froze. She was a rational woman. She believed in evidence. She believed in the billable hour. She did not believe in ghosts.

She walked toward the bedroom door. Her hand trembled as she reached for the knob.

It was cold. Ice cold.

She turned it.

The room was empty. The window was open, the curtains billowing in the freezing wind.

I closed that window, she thought. *I know I closed it.*

On her nightstand, her locket—the one her grandmother gave her—was missing. In its place was a single, dead fly.

Flashback. The Exorcism Begins.

The farmhouse was a fortress under siege. The windows were boarded up. The furniture was pushed against the walls.

Emily lay on the mattress in the living room. She was gaunt, her eyes sunken, her skin the color of old parchment. She hadn't eaten in days. She claimed the food turned to maggots in her mouth.

Father Moore stood over her. He was younger then, less broken, but the fear was already eating at him.

"We begin," he said.

He sprinkled holy water on her forehead.

Emily screamed. Steam rose from her skin where the water touched, as if she were a hot skillet.

"IT BURNS!" she shrieked. Her back arched, her ribs pushing against her skin like the bars of a cage trying to burst open. Her mouth opened so wide the corners of her lips tore, blood trickling down her chin. The sound was not a scream; it was a detonation of pain.

"Exorcizamus te, omnis immundus spiritus!" Moore chanted, his voice a hammer against the dark.

"Your Latin is sloppy, Priest!" The voice that came out of her was mocking, sophisticated. It sounded like a bored aristocrat. "You missed a declension."

"Who are you?" Moore demanded.

Emily's head swiveled. Her eyes locked onto his.

"I am the one who dwelt with Cain," the voice purred. "I am the one who kissed Judas."

Moore faltered. This wasn't just psychosis. This was history. Ancient, hateful history.

"Tell me your names!" he screamed.

And then, the room plunged into darkness.

Chapter 4: The Barn

The night of the final exorcism, the sky was a bruise of purple and black. The storm had knocked out the power lines for miles. The farmhouse was an island in a sea of darkness, lit only by the flickering glow of kerosene lamps and the lightning that tore the sky apart.

They moved her to the barn. The house couldn't hold it anymore. The walls were groaning, the pipes bursting. The entity—the entities—wanted space.

Emily was tied to the bedposts, but the ropes were fraying. She wasn't struggling. She was vibrating. A low, constant hum emanated from her body, like a generator on the verge of exploding.

Dr. Adani, the anthropologist Moore had called as a witness—no, as a safeguard—stood in the corner, clutching her recorder. She was shaking. She had studied possession in theory. In books. This was not a book. This was a meat grinder.

"Untie her," Moore said.

"Father, she'll hurt herself," Nathaniel, Emily's father, sobbed. He was holding his wife, Maria, who was praying the rosary so fast the words blurred into a single continuous hum.

"She needs to be free to choose," Moore said. "The rites require her will."

They untied the ropes.

For a moment, nothing happened. Emily lay still.

Then, she stood up. Not like a human stands up. She levitated, her heels dragging on the floor, her body rigid, as if hooked by an invisible wire.

The horses in the stalls went mad. They kicked against the wood, their screams blending with the thunder.

Emily's face was gone. In its place was a mask of contorted muscle and hate. Her eyes were black pits. Her tongue, swollen and purple, lolled out of her mouth.

"Do you think you can expel us, little man?" The voice was a chorus now. Many voices speaking in unison. A choir of the damned.

"By the power of the Lord Jesus Christ!" Moore held the crucifix up.

Emily laughed. It was the sound of glass breaking in a canyon.

She lunged.

She moved with the speed of a spider, scuttling up the wooden beams of the barn, defying gravity. She hung from the rafters, her head twisted 180 degrees to look down at them.

"WE ARE LEGION!"

The wind tore the barn doors off their hinges. Hay swirled like a cyclone. The horses broke free, trampling the dirt floor in panic.

Moore fell to his knees. "Names! I command you! Give me your names!"

Emily dropped. She landed on all fours in front of him, her face inches from his. Her breath smelled of sulfur and millennia of rot.

"One," she whispered, holding up a finger that was bent at a sickening angle. "I am the one who dwelt within Cain!"

Cain. The first murderer.

"Two!" Her voice changed, becoming serpentine. "I am the one who dwelt within Nero!"

Nero. The burner of Christians.

"Three!" A deep, guttural roar. "I once dwelt within Judas!"

Judas. The betrayer.

"Four!" A high, shrieking giggle. "I was with Legion!"

"Five!" A voice of cold, iron authority. "I am Belial!"

Moore was weeping. The weight of it was crushing him. The sheer magnitude of the evil.

"And I..."

Emily's face softened. For a second, she looked like herself. But her eyes were still burning.

"And I am Lucifer," she whispered. "The Devil in the flesh."

Moore screamed. The shockwave threw him back against the wall. The lamps exploded.

Darkness. Absolute darkness.

And in the dark, the sound of a girl weeping.

Chapter 5: The Sunrise Verdict

The jury was out for four days.

The waiting was a slow torture. Erin sat in the empty courtroom, staring at the seal of the state on the wall. *Justice. Integrity. Honor.* Words. Just words.

She had done her job. She had dismantled the prosecution's timeline. She had introduced the possibility—however slight—that Gambutrol had caused the toxicity that killed Emily. She had given them reasonable doubt.

But she hadn't saved Emily. No one had.

Moore sat beside her. He was at peace.

"It doesn't matter, Erin," he said.

"It matters to me," she said. "I don't like losing."

"You didn't lose," Moore said. "You told the story. People know now. They know that there are forces... beyond."

The door opened. The bailiff stepped in.

"We have a verdict."

The courtroom was packed. Reporters, family members, the curious.

"Will the defendant please rise."

Moore stood. Erin stood beside him. She could feel his arm trembling. Not from fear. From exhaustion.

"In the case of The People vs. Richard Moore..."

The foreman, the man with the calloused hands, looked at Moore. He didn't look away.

"...we find the defendant... Guilty of Negligent Homicide."

Erin closed her eyes. It was a punch to the gut.

"However," the foreman continued. "We recommend a sentence of... time served."

A gasp went through the room.

Ethan Thomas slammed his pen down. It was a conviction, technically. But it was a victory for the defense. A slap on the wrist. Acknowledgment that while the law had been broken, justice... justice was something else.

Judge Brewster banged his gavel. "Order! Order!"

He looked at the jury. He looked at Moore.

"Given the extraordinary circumstances... and the jury's recommendation... the defendant is sentenced to time served. He is free to go."

Outside, the snow was melting. The sun was weak, but it was there.

Erin walked Moore to the car.

"Where will you go?" she asked.

"Back to the parish," Moore said. "There is work to be done."

He turned to her. He reached into his pocket and pulled out a locket. *Her* locket. The one that had vanished from her apartment.

Erin stared at it. "How..."

"I found it," Moore said simply. "On the steps of the church this morning. I think... I think she wanted you to have it back."

Erin took it. The metal was warm.

"She?"

"Emily," Moore said. "She made it through, Erin. She didn't let them win. In the end... she died free."

He got into the car.

Erin stood on the sidewalk. The city moved around her—taxis, pedestrians, the noise of life. But for a moment, the world felt thinner. Like a veil.

She looked at the locket. She looked at the sky.

"Goodbye, Emily," she whispered.

She turned and walked into the crowd. She was a Senior Partner now. She had won.

But as she walked, she avoided the shadows. Because she knew now. She knew what was waiting in the dark.

And she knew that sometimes, the only defense... was belief.

THE END